GIRDA BREAD, KASHMIR



In Kashmir (Srinagar, to be specific), Zacharias had an epiphany. He realised that bread isn't eaten as part of a main meal like everyone assumes, but instead is restricted to breakfast or tea time. "They have a different bread for every need [in Kashmir] and they come in varied shapes and size," he says. Of all the varieties, *girda* was one that caught his eye. "It is flattened by hand and patterned with finger impressions. It is crunchy on the outside and soft within, with a subtle sourness from the addition of yoghurt." Zaharias learned about this process at a *kandur* (old bakery) near the Hazratbal Shrine. He likens the process to poetry in motion: shaping the bread, putting it in a tandoor, removing the freshly baked bread, and handing it to customers.

WILD FOODS, CHORLA GHAT

"When people think of Goan food, they think of Catholic/ Portuguese or Goan Saraswat cuisine. But there are indigenous communities [in Goa] whose cuisine is so different," says Zacharias. During a recent trip, he spent a day foraging for wild food in the Chorla Ghats with a member of the Gaonkar community. "We ate [what we foraged] for lunch. It was cooked very simply, with barely any spices—green chilli and sometimes onion," he says. His plate had tender bamboo shoots cooked with dried peas, wild greens like *nali bhaji* and *karado* and a tomato *saar*. "It's so far removed from how we think of Indian food in the restaurant context, not overly complicated, where the ingredient gets to shine." ■

